

American Intonation — The System, and What To Do

Notation: CAPS = the strong syllable · ə = the lazy “uh”, short and vague · ↘ ↗ = pitch falls or rises, *starting on the CAPS syllable*. So də-VEL-əp-mənt reads: mush, **STRONG**, mush, mush.

1. Why you have an accent

English has no gaps between words. So how does an American find where one word ends and the next begins?

They guess, using one shortcut: **a strong syllable means a new word is starting**. It works because most English words begin strong.

Now say *development* the French way — four clear syllables, roughly equal length. To their ear, that’s four word-beginnings. The shortcut returns nonsense and they fall back on slow, effortful parsing.

That’s your accent. Not your R, not your TH. You’re handing your listener four words where you meant one. It’s also exactly why people say “*his English is perfect, but he’s tiring to listen to.*”

Which gives you the one sentence everything else depends on:

English stress isn’t something you add to a syllable. It’s a contrast you create by destroying the syllables around it.

You already hit the right syllable much of the time. You never destroy the neighbours. That’s the job.

The other half of the problem: French puts its emphasis at the **end of a phrase**. English puts it on a **specific syllable inside a specific word**, usually mid-phrase. Your melody is fine — it’s anchored in the wrong place. That’s what people hear as “French sing-song.”

Two problems: **timing** and **anchoring**. Everything below fixes one or the other.

2. The whole system, on one sentence

I think the development team’s estimate is probably a bit optimistic.

What you probably say now: every syllable full and roughly equal, with a rise at the end. Twenty-odd audible beats where an American gives six.

Layer 1 — destroy the weak syllables. də-VEL-əp-mənt. estimate as a noun is ES-tə-mət — the ending is mush, not “mate”. probably → PROB-ly, a whole syllable vanishes. the, is, a → thə, əz, ə.

Layer 2 — stress where the word says. deVELopment, not developMENT. ESTimate, not estIMATE.

Layer 3 — one word carries the point. Each chunk gets exactly one main emphasis, and everything after it goes flat and low:

I think the deVELOpment team's EStimate is PROBly a bit op-tə-MIS-tic

And if you've already been discussing the estimate, it disappears entirely — because **English deletes emphasis on anything already mentioned:**

I think it's PROBly a bit op-tə-MIS-tic

Layer 4 — choose a tune.

˘ op-tə-MIS-tic — flat assertion. Reads as: *your estimate is wrong.* ˘˘ op-tə-MIS-tic — falls on MIS, floats back up across -tic. Reads as: *I have a reservation, and I'm leaving you room.*

Same words. Different meeting.

Reduce → stress → emphasize → tune. Plus ear training, which has to come first. Five stages.

3. The five stages

Each ends in a gate — a test you run on yourself. Don't skip ahead; that's the main way people lose a year.

Stage 0 — Get your ear working

Two weeks of focus, then 5 minutes a day forever.

Every drill in existence says “compare yourself to a native model.” That's useless if you can't hear the difference — and there's a well-documented finding that French speakers specifically struggle to *store* stress information, even when they hear it in the moment. Skip this stage and you'll practise diligently for six months against a standard you can't perceive, consolidating your errors. That's the most common way this fails.

Do: build a scored quiz. Take 60 words you're unsure of. Get 3–4 different voices for each (Forvo, YouGlish, a couple of TTS voices). Shuffle words *and* voices. For each clip, answer one question: **which syllable is stressed?** Check immediately. **Write your score down.** 15 minutes most days — any audio flashcard app does this.

Gate: 85% or better, shuffled voices, two sessions in a row.

Stage 1 — Make weak syllables genuinely weak

The biggest single win. You'll live here a while.

First, four things you physically need — about five hours, once, then done:

- **A real schwa.** Not the French *deux/peur* vowel — that one's rounded and too clear, and Americans hear it as a **full** vowel, i.e. as a new word. Say “uh” like a shrug, lips completely relaxed. *Check in a mirror: if your lips move forward, it's wrong.*

- **The American -er** (better, manager, computer). Say “uh”, then pull your tongue back and slightly up until the sound darkens. No French R scrape — a weak syllable with friction in it isn’t weak.
- **Syllabic consonants.** button = BUT-n. Never open your mouth after the T. Say BUT-ən and you’ve turned two syllables into three beats.
- **Unreleased final consonants.** Say stop and freeze with your lips shut. That little trailing -ə you add after final T/P/K lands exactly where English wants a clean ending.

Do: build outward from the beat, never left to right — TAH → TAH-grəf → fə-TAH-grə-fi. Then the metronome test at 90 bpm: say DOGS EAT BONES and The dogs would have EATen all of the BONES in the **same total time**. Three beats each; 3 syllables versus 12.

Exaggerate everything to 300%. Then, once, record what feels like a ridiculous parody of an American and play it back — it will sound like a mild, pleasant accent. That single discovery changes how hard you’re willing to push.

Gate: record yourself saying *administration*. Measure your longest and shortest syllable.

Ratio of 3:1 or better. Americans run 3:1 to 5:1; you’re probably at 1.5:1.

Stage 2 — Fix the stress on your own vocabulary

Fast — weeks, not months. Start here for morale.

This is knowledge, not motor skill, so it moves quickly.

Do: record yourself reading a page of your actual work writing. Check every word of 3+ syllables against a US dictionary with audio. Every miss goes on a running list in your notes app, reviewed weekly. **That list is worth more than any generic table.**

Four rules cover most professional vocabulary:

- **The -ion family** (-ion, -ial, -ious, -ual, -ian): stress the syllable immediately before it. adminiSTRation, esSENTial, poliTiCian. One rule, thousands of words.
- **-ic, -ity:** same. econOMIC, aBILity.
- **-ate verbs, -logy, -graphy:** stress **two** syllables before. CALculate, phoT0graphy.
- **-ary/-ory/-ery:** stress hard left, mush everything after — NEsəseri, LABrətori. Your worst minefield, because every French equivalent is late-stressed.

And one heuristic that saves you constantly: **if a word looks French and you don’t know the stress, guess earlier than feels natural.** The French pull is always rightward.

Gate: dictate a paragraph of your own writing to your phone’s speech recognition. It should transcribe your long words correctly. Systematic misfires point straight at systematic stress errors — free, blunt, unbiased.

Stage 3 — Put the emphasis where you mean it

Where “understood” becomes “understood correctly.”

One chunk, one main emphasis — and **everything after it goes flat and dead**. That second part is what French speakers find hardest, because your instinct is to hold your voice up until the final syllable and then drop.

Do: drill long tails until they stay at the floor.

It's about the \MANagement. / That's the \DIFficulty. / It was comPLETEly \UNnecessary.

This one drill removes most of the sing-song impression.

Then learn that moving the emphasis changes the sentence entirely:

\I didn't say he stole it. (*someone else said it*) I didn't \SAY he stole it. (*I implied it*) I didn't say he \STOLE it. (*he borrowed it*)

Six placements, six meanings, one string of words. **In French you'd do this with syntax** — *ce n'est pas moi qui l'ai dit*. English does it with pitch and assumes you will too. So you produce flawless English in which your actual point goes unmarked. In a negotiation, that's expensive.

And delete the emphasis on old information — this is grammar, not manners:

"Where's the report?" → "I \LEFT it on your desk." ✓ not "I left the report on your \DESK." ✗

Gate: produce all six placements of *I didn't say he stole it* on demand, and state what each one means.

Stage 4 — Melody

Six tunes. Six well-controlled beats twelve half-controlled.

Tune	Feels like	Used for
Fall \	done, committed	statements, commands, wh-questions
Low rise ↗	genuine question	yes/no questions
Fall-rise \↗	"...but"	hedging, doubt, polite disagreement
Rise-fall ↗\	strong, impressed	emphasis, contrast
High rise ↗	"I'm not finished"	continuation, storytelling
Flat →	routine, bored	lists, transactions

Two quick wins, do them this week. Wh-questions **fall** — Where are you ↘G0ing? In French they rise, and rising in English makes you sound permanently unsure. And **falls must reach the floor**; stopping mid-range reads as evasive or unfinished.

The one that matters professionally is the fall-rise. Without it you have exactly two options — flat assertion or question. So every reservation you have comes out as a flat assertion, and that is precisely why competent non-native professionals get read as blunt or cold.

“That won’t ↘WORK.” → dismissive “I’m not sure that’ll ↘/↗WORK.” → a normal colleague

Produce it: start mid, jump up on the strong syllable, drop, then float back up. Trace it with your hand. It’ll feel theatrical — do it too big for a few weeks and it normalizes.

And know this: enthusiasm in English is carried by **pitch**, not word choice. “That’s great” with a narrow range means “fine, whatever.” If colleagues think you’re lukewarm about things you’re excited about, that’s why.

Gate: say *You’re going to Paris* with all six tunes, and state what each one means.

4. How to practise

30 minutes daily genuinely beats 3.5 hours on Sunday — motor skills consolidate during sleep, so spacing does something massing can’t.

- 5 min ear quiz, scored, written down
- 5 min warm-up drill for your current stage
- 15 min current stage: chorus with a model → shadow it → say it alone
- 5 min record a 2-min monologue. Review 30 seconds. Check ONE thing.

Four rules that matter more than any exercise:

- 1. One thing per session.** You can consciously monitor roughly *one* dimension at a time. Name it out loud before you start — “today, only vowel reduction” — and let everything else be bad.
- 2. Drill it, then scramble it.** Reps to find the movement, then **mix it randomly** with other material. People who only drill in blocks are flawless in practice and revert the instant they’re in a real conversation. This is the number one reason pronunciation work fails to transfer.
- 3. Predict before you check.** Record yourself, **write down what you think went wrong**, and only then compare to the model. Judging first is what trains your ear.
- 4. Climb the ladder for every new thing.** Chorus → shadow → from memory → marked-up reading → plain reading → retelling → prepared monologue → 2 min spontaneous → real conversation. Every new feature starts at the bottom.

Two things to actively avoid. Slowing down to be clearer — it backfires, because it stretches your *weak* syllables and flattens the exact contrast clarity depends on. And **suppressing your melody** because someone said you sound sing-song — don't reduce the movement, *relocate* it.

Timeline: word stress moves in weeks · careful speech, 1–3 months · spontaneous speech, 4–8 months of daily work · how people perceive you, 6–18 months.

5. The part that isn't technical

Doing this properly will feel like pretending, and a wide American pitch range will feel theatrical — even slightly undignified — to a French sensibility. Most people hold back for exactly this reason, and it's the invisible ceiling on otherwise diligent practice.

Frame it as **a role, not a replacement**. You're adding a register, not deleting your French self — bilinguals routinely have a different voice in each language. Practise as a character first, privately, deliberately over the top. The physical skills transfer fine, and performance mode carries no self-consciousness.

Your target — **completely clear, native-like rhythm, still audibly French** — isn't a compromise. It's the best goal available, and far more achievable than passing for American.